All the Stars Burned Black for Dumbo

By Jared Botticelli

A MAN sits alone on a park bench. For a moment, he observes the crowd around him and then, haltingly, speaks to an unknown bystander (the judge)

MAN: **(Pg 3-9)** This is a nice park, don't you think? Always kids here with their parents, when the weather's good. Playing on the monkey-bars, asking for just five more minutes of pushes on the swings. I like this park. It's good to just [be] here and watch the kids and their parents being happy.

Hey, you got a minute? Well, probably more like five minutes.

INTRODUCTION

In life, choices are inevitable. Although they start small – the monkey bars or the swings – as we age, we are presented with monumental choices that have the power to shape the course of our everyday lives. For it is not the stars that hold our destiny, but ourselves. Every choice comes with a consequence and those consequences can be uplifting or devastating. Your stars may burn brightly or they may burn black.

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MAN: My wife's name is Brittney. B. I usually just call her B. Sometimes, when you know someone so well, you can just say it with one little letter. B. She just graduated from, um, teacher's college. Incredible. Long, dark hair, amazing smile. She makes a killer cappuccino. Yeah. I didn't want her to work while she was in school, but, uh, bills, you know? You gotta do what you gotta do.

We've been married almost three years. I knew her all the way through high school, and, uh, she helped me with my chemistry, my physics- B's the only reason I actually passed Calculus, with a C minus, but I passed. So we knew each other and we were friends but I never thought I was good enough, you know? We started seeing each other after we graduated and I guess she saw something in me that I, uh, didn't see. Still don't. B just does everything for the right reasons . . . Her star just burns bright because it does, you know?

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She's just. . . I just love her.

. . . You know how sometimes you make one crappy decision, just one, right? And then everything after that, well, it just sort of builds on itself and gets bigger and bigger? Well, I, uh, that is, a couple of months ago - 9 weeks? ten maybe, it's sort of jumbled up now . . . it was a Friday and one of those crap days at work. I'd screwed up and I wasn't sure exactly how I was going to fix it, you know? And a few of the people from the office were going to go out. B was done with class already and didn't work that night so I called her to tell her I was going to pick her up, and uh, she tells me that she didn't go to her last class, that her stomach was kind of upset and she didn't feel too good. And then she tells me she really wants some tomato juice, and asks if I can pick some up for her, right? And I just thought that was the kookiest thing, right? She tells me she's okay, though, and that I should just go ahead and go. And she says, "I love you, Dumbo" and she hangs up. And, uh, normally I wouldn't go anywhere after work without B, but it's been a lousy day, and B suggested it, so I decide to go. You would've done the same thing, right? Right. . .

So, we go to that place off of 3rd and Alder -- they had live music on Fridays. And it was me and three of the other guys and uh, Debbie, this new girl they'd hired as a receptionist. I was only going to stay for a drink or two, but we all started to play this game of trying to guess what song the band was playing . . . uh . . . what's that song . . . Losing My Religion . . . "That's me in the corner, that's me in the spotlight, losing my religion . . . *" I notice this girl, Debbie, she's putting her hand on my leg under the table. I don't think a whole lot about it, right? But the hour hand is moving on the clock and then out of nowhere it's last call and everybody's talking about going home and it turns out Debbie lives on B's and my side of town, so, I offer to drive her, no problem. *(Long beat)*

So, I get to Debbie's house and she says I should really come in for coffee before I go home. And I think, I probably shouldn't, but, B's for sure sleeping at this point, so, I. . . uh . . . I do. I go in, and this girl, Debbie, she, uh, she doesn't make any coffee. *(long guilty pause)* I'm sure you get the idea. *(long beat)* It was around, I don't know, four in the morning. Debbie is

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sleeping but I get up and I throw up, two or three times and then I look in the mirror, but I don't recognize the person that I see there. No. That guy's not me. I don't know him. The guy that's me is the guy that lives in a small house with one large cat named Marbles and has a wife who he loves more than he thought was humanly possible. Not the ... uh ... thing I saw in that mirror in that apartment that night. I didn't know him. I still don't.

So . . . uh . . . I go out to my car. And I'm not doing so good. I'm driving and the lights are all whizzing past me and I'm trying hard to breathe but it's like there's a heavy granite block sitting on my chest. And it only takes me a few minutes to get home, because, uh, B and I, we don't live very far away. *(long beat)* I realize right off that there's something wrong. And the something that's wrong is that B's car isn't in the driveway. It's not here. And so, of course, the first thing that I'm thinking, [is] that B was there at the bar, watching, listening when I was singing: "losing my religion . . .*" and she saw that girl, that Debbie, get in my car and saw me drive her back to her apartment. [That] somehow, B was watching through a window or something when I, uh. . . stopped being myself with Debby. Turned into that something else. The other guy that I don't know.

So, walking up to our door, I'm thinking, B hates me now, she knows and she hates me. I push the door open. I turn on all the lights in the house, cuz I need to get rid of the darkness, ya know? And there's this note on the refrigerator, a note in B's little perfect handwriting: "I hope you're having a good time. I felt a little better, so I went out to get the tomato juice - just wanted you to know in case you get back before I do. I love you, Dumbo. -B."

I wait. I go outside on the porch, and I wait. And I look up and I see all of the stars in the night sky, and I wonder why they look like they do. I mean, they go on and on forever and I start to wonder how they can just burn and burn like that. It's like, uh, 3:45 in the morning and B isn't home. And so of course I'm thinking, she knows. I feel like my brain is trying to squeeze itself out of my head and I don't know what to do so I wait. And it's 4:00. And it's

4:13. And it's 4:24. And it's 4:46. And it's 4:58.

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And then it's 5:04. I'll always remember that. 5:04. Because at 5:04, the phone rings, and I'm thinking, gee whiz, thank goodness, B just got a flat tire or went over to see her sister and she's calling to say she's spending the night there.

(Answering the phone) "Hello" *(realizes it's not B).*

This voice on the other end of the line is asking me, "Are you Britney Johnson's husband"

"Yes, I am, what's going on?"

And the voice on the other end of the line is telling me, "Sir, I'm very sorry to have to inform you of this . . ."

And I guess I'm hearing this guy's voice coming through the line, but it sounds like someone dead is talking to me. I can't really listen because I have to go down to the police station . . . *(at the station)* I have to show my ID and then go down this elevator and it sort of feels like I'm going straight down to hell or something. I come into this room with lots of silver metal and watch while this guy pulls out this drawer, and uh, he pulls back a sheet and uh . . . huh. . . on that big cold silver drawer thing is my B . . . my Britney . . . the girl who helped me pass Calculus and named me Dumbo . . . and uh . . . made me worth something . . . she's lying there and she's all messed up . . . real bad . . . *(breaks down, cradles 'B's body and screams)*

It's time to go home now . . . we have to go home . . . I am so f***** sorry! We just need to go home. *(his voice gets softer and softer as the realization sets in – To audience)* But, uh, we couldn't go home together. We couldn't. *(Long beat)*

I don't really look into mirrors anymore because, uh, I don't recognize myself. Or, I guess, the myself that I used to be. *(long beat)* Sometimes we make a really crappy decision and then everything ends up being all our fault. You know what I mean, right? We go to some bar some Friday night and we start sing, "That's me in the corner, that's me in the spotlight*" and then suddenly we're in some apartment with some girl and we go home only to find that our life, our light, our everything, was hit by a drunk driver on her way out for tomato juice. Tomato juice I was supposed to buy.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
OK State Qualifier

**Music and Lyrics to "Losing My Religion" by REM can be found here*
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xwtdhWltSIg

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